

BLUEGRASS Mandolin

For The Complete

IGNORAMUS!

by
**Wayne
Erbsen**

CD Included

Bluegrass Mandolin for the Complete Ignoramus!

by
Wayne Erbsen



This One



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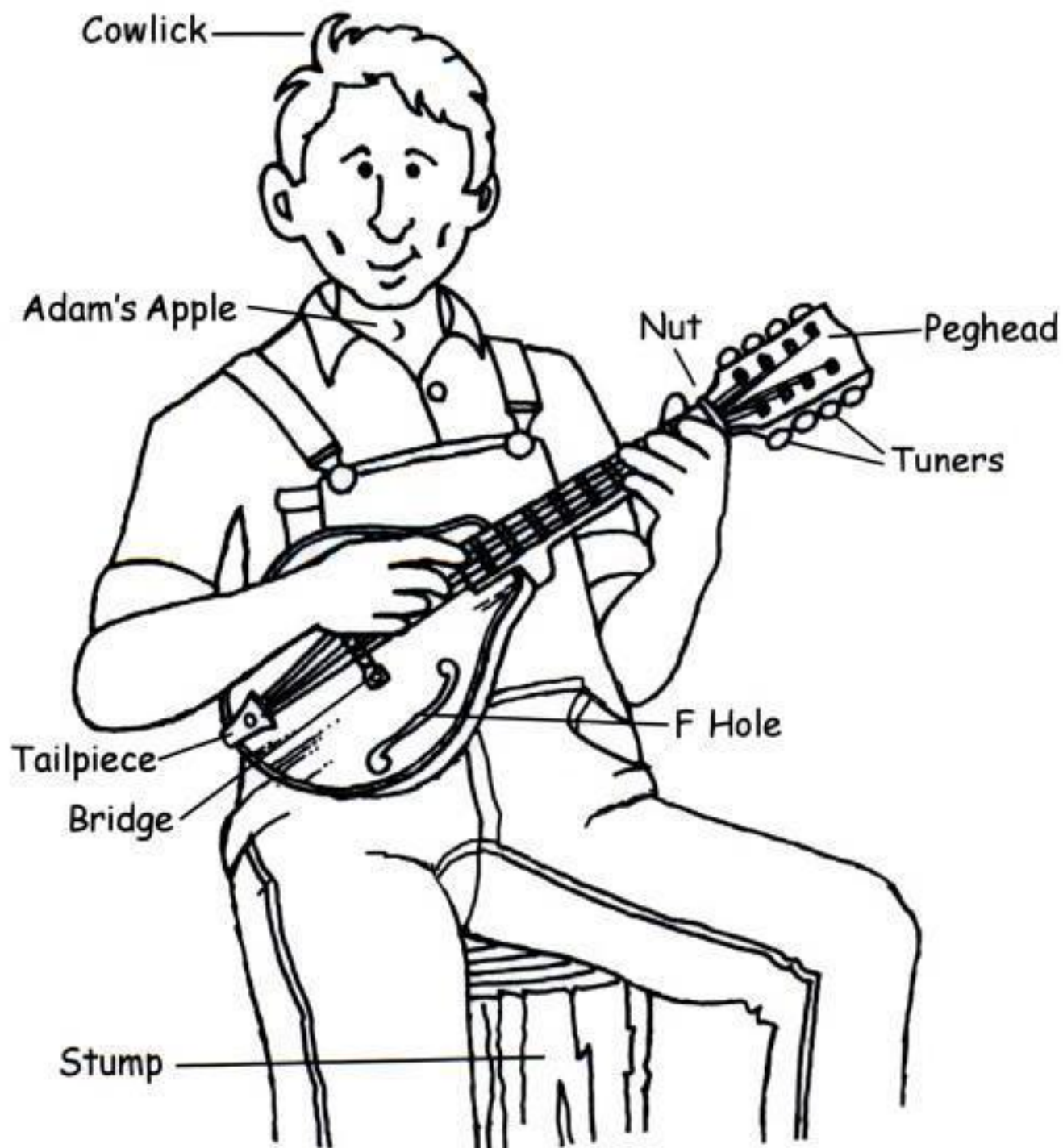
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Photo by Martin Fox

Parts of a Mandolin(ist)



Tuning Your Mandolin

Job one will be getting your mandolin in tune. Good luck! If you've never tuned a stringed instrument before, you might need help. Ask a friend who plays mandolin or guitar to give you a hand tuning it. You can always throw yourself on the mercy of your local music store; they will surely take pity on you. If no help can be found, fine. You can tune it yourself.

ELECTRONIC TUNER: I highly recommend you purchase an electronic tuner to help you get in tune. These little gadgets are easily available at your local music store. Be sure to bring your mandolin with you when you purchase a tuner and get the salesperson to show you how it works. Heck, why don't you get him or her to go ahead and tune your mandolin for you so you can start out on the right foot. You can reward them by being a loyal customer.

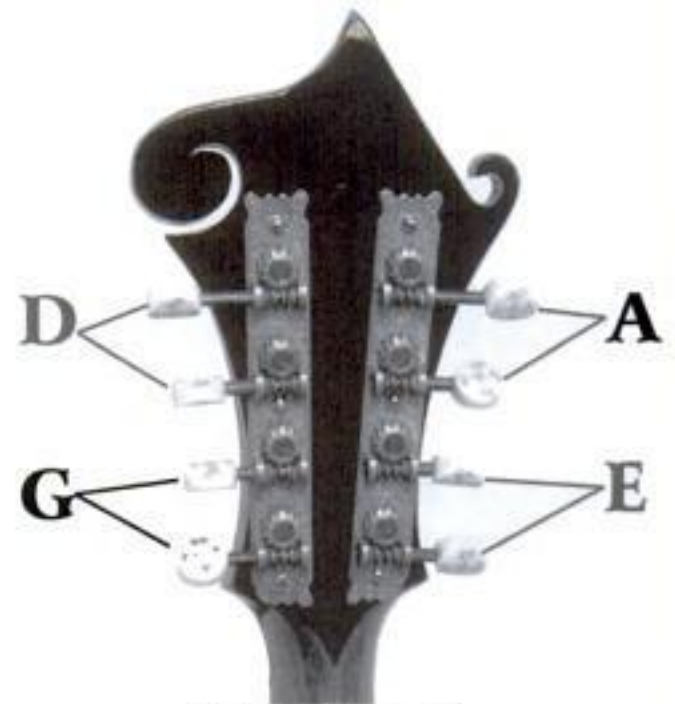


Photo by Martin Fox

The Strings of the Mandolin

1st = E, 2nd = A, 3rd = D, 4th = G



USING YOUR ELECTRONIC TUNER: Although electronic tuners vary from one brand to another, they all basically do the same thing: tell you the name of the note you're playing, and whether it's too high or too low. Check out the names of the strings in the box above. You'll need to memorize the names of your strings, and the sooner the better. To help you memorize them, you can make up your own acronym or use this one: "Elephants Always Do Go." Remember that the 1st string is the string that's closest to the floor, when you are holding your mandolin in playing position.

TUNING TIPS: When you're tuning your mandolin, I suggest starting with the E strings, and then go on to the A, D and G. With your mandolin on your lap, you will turn the E and A string pegs clockwise to make the string go up, or sharp, in musician's lingo. On the G and D strings, turning the peg counterclockwise will make the string go sharp. With your pick try to play and tune only one string at a time, no small trick.



Tablature or "Tab" for Ignoramuses

If you are a true and total beginner who doesn't read music, I have good news: all the tunes in the book are written out in an easy-to-read tab system that I invented. A line of tab will be right above a corresponding line of music, so if you sorta read music, you can look at both the tab and the music.

Take a look over at page 13 and almost half way down you'll see an example of the tab. It consists of four horizontal lines which represent the four pairs of strings on the mandolin. The E, or highest string, is found toward the top of the page and the G, or lowest string, is toward the bottom of the page. You'll notice that each string is marked on the left with its name. A letter on the string tells you the name of the note to play on that string.

TIMING: The timing in the tab matches the timing of the music. If you don't read music, no problem! Here's all you need to know. Each line of tab is divided into measures, which are the spaces between the "fence posts." At the beginning of the first line of music it will say 2/4, 3/4 or 4/4. The number on top tells you that each measure will either get two, three or four beats. Each beat is one tap of your foot (down and up). In the example below, look at the first line of the Carter Family song, "Keep on the Sunny Side of Life." The first two notes are both eighth notes. Your foot would go DOWN on the first eighth note and UP on the second. Then you'll see two notes with a single vertical line attached to it. Those are quarter notes and they each get one beat. For each quarter note, your foot would go DOWN-UP. In measure two, there are two pairs of eighth notes, so your foot would go DOWN or UP on each note. In measure 3, you'll see a D note with two lines attached. The two lines tell you it's a half note and gets two beats. This D note connects with a tie to a D note in measure 4, so the D note would get a total of three beats, or three DOWN-UPS with your foot.



	G		C		G		
E	1		2		3		4
A	B		A		D		B
D	E		G		D		G
G	G		E		D		G

There's a dark and a troubled side of life. There's a

Above the tab is a "G" and a "C" which are your chords. Take a look at page 15, to find vital information on playing the chords. On page 78 are simple rhythmic chord positions to play while you are singing and strumming the rhythm.



Amazing Grace

No hymn can rival "Amazing Grace" in popularity. The composer of the lyrics was John Newton, who was born in England in 1725. When he was nine, his mother died, and he was shipped off to sea as a cabin boy. He later deserted the British navy and was whipped and put in irons. Rising through the ranks, he eventually became captain of a slave ship. During a violent storm, Newton found solace in God and he later left the sea to become an ordained minister of the Church of England. After composing the lyrics to "Amazing Grace" in 1789, Newton set the words to an anonymous tune that often appears in old hymn books as "New Britain" or "Harmony Grove."

	Index		Ring	
A	B		D	
D	E		G	

It's a good thing for us that John Newton named this classic hymn "Amazing Grace" because it comes at the front of the alphabet, and it's easier to start pickin' on a tune you already know and love.

The first thing you should notice about "Amazing Grace" is that it's in 3/4, or waltz, time. That means there are three beats per measure and the rhythm sounds like "ONE, two-three, ONE, two-three." Before you start, take a look at the chart on the top right hand corner of this page. This handy diagram will tell you exactly which notes will be used to play "Amazing Grace." Notice that we'll be using our index finger to play B and E and our ring finger to play the G and high D. Let your middle and pinky fingers rest for now.

ICE COLD LICKS: First, play the unadorned melody as written on the facing page. Remember that every note with a single vertical line attached to it gets one beat. If there is a double line, that note gets two beats. If there's a dot after a note, it gets half again the value of the note preceding it. For example, measure 7 will get three beats because it has a dotted double line.



WARM LICKS: After you can play the simple melody of "Amazing Grace," you're ready to juice up the rhythm a little. Of course, this isn't the kind of tune you want to go crazy with, so please try to restrain yourself. "Amazing Grace" is the perfect tune to try the Tremolo, which is the "mother" of all mandolin licks. (See page 73). You can use the Tremolo on any of the notes EXCEPT the 8th notes (which are tied together like the B and G in measure 1.)



Harmony Notes

All the melody notes of "Amazing Grace" are on the D or A strings. To play the harmony of any melody note on the D string, simply play the G string open along with the melody note. For melody notes on the A string, you'll find the harmony by playing the D string open.



Cryin' Holy Unto the Lord

The Carter Family called this song "On the Rock Where Moses Stood" when they recorded it in Memphis, Tennessee, on November 24, 1930, but the song can be traced to African-American sources much earlier. Bill Monroe recorded it in Atlanta, Georgia, on October 7, 1940, but Monroe's version is suspiciously similar to that of Wade Mainer & The Sons of The Mountaineers, who recorded it on February 4, 1939.

	Index	Middle	Ring
A	B $\flat$	B	C
D		E	
			D
			G

ICE COLD LICKS: This slightly spooky melody awaits you. Notice that in measures 5 and 6 you'll be playing a B flat, which is the A string fretted at the first fret with your index finger. In measures 2, 4, and 8, there is a dotted half note, which gets three beats.



WARM LICKS: On any of the half notes, you can play the Gallop, as shown on the Mandolin Rhythms on page 73. Since each Gallop takes up one quarter note, and there are two quarter notes in a half note, for each half note, you can play the Gallop twice. On the dotted half notes in measures 2 and 4, you can play the Gallop three times.

HOT LICKS: In addition to the Gallop on the half notes, you can also use the Porcupine (page 73) and/or the Watermelon (page 74).



Jack Shelton, Tiny Dotson, Wade Mainer, Howard Dixon

Harmony Notes

All the melody notes in "Crying Holy Unto the Lord" are on the D or A strings. To play the harmony of any melody note on the D string, simply play the G string open. For melody notes on the A string, you'll find the harmony by playing the D string open.



Down the Road

It never fails that "Down the Road" is a hit with my mandolin students. That's because it's one of those songs that simply sounds great, and that's how we're going to play it: simply. The first bluegrass version of this tune was the hot 1950s recording by Flatt & Scruggs, but they didn't sing a chorus. In the early 1960s, the Greenbriar Boys came along and added a chorus, which they probably made up. The song is actually much older than the Flatt & Scruggs recording. Uncle Dave Macon recorded a rousing rendition on July 25, 1928, that he called "Over the Road I'm Bound to Go." The melody is basically the same as the tune "Ida Red," which was first recorded by Fiddlin' Powers & Family on August 19, 1924.

	Index			Ring	
		B		D	
D		E		G	

ICE COLD LICKS: Just play the melody. Be sure to play the quarter notes with a DOWN stroke and each pair of eighth notes with a DOWN-UP stroke of your pick.



WARM LICKS: After you're comfortable playing the basic melody of "Down the Road," you're ready to use the mandolin rhythm I call the "Watermelon." I call it that because it has four quick 16th notes that correspond to the four syllables of the word "wa-ter-mel-on." Besides that, I've been eating my share of watermelons lately.



Let me show you how the Watermelon works. Look at the first four notes of "Down the Road," which are G, G, G and E — all quarter notes played on the D string. Since each quarter note gets one beat, tap your foot four times and say out loud, "G, G, G, E." Every time you say one of the letters, your foot should hit the floor and come up. Now tap your foot four times again, this time saying "watermelon," with each foot tap. To play the Watermelon on "Down the Road," fret the D string at the fifth fret, which will give you a G. With your pick, go DOWN-UP, DOWN-UP three times on the G note and one time on the E. Congratulations, you've just played four Watermelons.

HOT LICKS: Once you get the Watermelon under control in measure 1, you can use it to play on any or all of the quarter notes in this or practically any song. Even better, you can alternate the Watermelon with any quarter note. For example, on the first four notes of measure 1, try alternating the Watermelon with just a single note, which for fun we'll call a "Spam." First, say "Watermelon, Spam, Watermelon, Spam," tapping your foot once for each word. Then play it that way on the mandolin. When you can do that, reverse it, saying and then playing "Spam, Watermelon, Spam, Watermelon." Presto! You're improvising.



RED HOT LICKS: You can use Echo Notes to dress up the naked quarter notes of "Down the Road." Any time the melody is a G on the D string, you can play an open G as a drone. On the E notes you can also play the G as a drone. (Page 74.)



Handsome Molly

Sung under such titles as "Loving Hannah," "Hannah My Love," "The Lover's Lament," "The Irish Girl," and even "Pretty Polly," this song was first recorded by G.B. Grayson and Henry Whitter on October 10, 1927. The Stanley Brothers recorded it for King records on January 16, 1961. This version is from the CD, *Rural Roots of Bluegrass*, as sung by Laura Boosinger and Wayne Erbsen.

	Index	Ring
A	B	D
D	E	G

ICE COLD LICKS. Play just the straight-ahead melody of "Handsome Molly."



WARM LICKS: Instead of playing the A string open at the end of measure 2, you can add a slide. When you finish playing the G note in measure 2, simply slide the G from the fifth fret to the seventh fret, which will produce an A note. As is often the case in situations like this, you can then play the D string fretted at the seventh fret along with the A string open.



HOT LICKS: If you like, you can add the Going t' Town lick on the D notes of measure 1. Instead of playing the quarter notes in measures 2, 3 and 4 you can simply play Going t' as you can hear on track 37 of the CD.



Photo by Wayne Erbsen



Keep on the Sunny Side of Life

No song is more associated with the Carter Family than "Keep on the Sunny Side of Life." Although it was considered their theme song,

it was actually composed in 1899 with lyrics by Ada Blenkhorn and music by J. Howard Entwisle. Blenkhorn was inspired to write the words when her invalid cousin insisted that she push his wheel chair down "the sunny side of the street."

	Index	Middle	Ring
E			
A	B	C	D
D	E	F#	G



Even though the song was recorded as early as 1910 on a cylinder, it was the Carter Family who made it popular. They recorded it at their second session for Victor on May 9, 1928, and again on May 8, 1935, for the American Record Company. Given the song's wide popularity, it is interesting that it has not been recorded more often. Perhaps its close association with the Carter Family has dimmed its appeal to other recording artists. Whatever the reason, let's pick it!

ICE COLD LICKS: You'll find "Keep on the Sunny Side of Life" pretty straightforward to play. There's nothing quirky about the timing or the choice of notes, so this song should fall easily under the magic of your fingers.



COOL LICKS: "Keep on the Sunny Side of Life" is the perfect song to strut your Porcupine lick (page 73). You can play one Porcupine for each quarter note. In measure 3, you can play the Porcupine twice, since the half note is the same as two quarter notes (this is **HIGHER MATH**).

HOT LICKS: On any of the quarter notes, alternate your Gallop with your Porcupine licks.



Harmony Notes

All the melody notes of "Keep on the Sunny Side of Life" are found on the D, A or E strings. When the melody is on the D string, you can play the G string open as a harmony note. On melody notes that are found on the A string, the harmony is the D string open.



"Keep on The Sunny Side" - A.P. Carter's epitaph



Key of G Keep on the Sunny Side of Life

Tempo: March-Like

The musical score is written in G major (one sharp) and 2/4 time. It consists of a piano accompaniment and a vocal melody. The piano part uses a four-staff system (E, A, D, G) with chords indicated by letters and numbers. The vocal part is on a single staff with a treble clef and a key signature of one sharp. The lyrics are written below the vocal staff.

Chords and Measures:

- Measure 1: G₁ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)
- Measure 2: C₂ (Chord: C4, E4, G4)
- Measure 3: G₃ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)
- Measure 4: G₄ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)
- Measure 5: D₅ (Chord: D4, F#4, A4)
- Measure 6: D₆ (Chord: D4, F#4, A4)
- Measure 7: D₇ (Chord: D4, F#4, A4)
- Measure 8: D₈ (Chord: D4, F#4, A4)
- Measure 9: G₉ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)
- Measure 10: G₁₀ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)
- Measure 11: G₁₁ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)
- Measure 12: G₁₂ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)
- Measure 13: D₁₃ (Chord: D4, F#4, A4)
- Measure 14: D₁₄ (Chord: D4, F#4, A4)
- Measure 15: G₁₅ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)
- Measure 16: G₁₆ (Chord: G4, B4, D5)

Lyrics:

There's a dark and troubled side of life, There's a
 bright and a sunny side too, Though we
 meet with the dark - ness and strife, The
 sunny side we al - so may view.

CHORUS: Keep on the sunny side always on the sunny side,
 Keep on the sunny side of life,
 It will help us every day it will brighten all our way,
 If we keep on the sunny side of life.



My Home's Across the Blue Ridge Mtns.

Key of G

Tempo: Third Gear

G^{1,8}

1

2

How can I keep from cry - in'?

D⁵

3

G¹ **G⁴**

4

How can I keep from cry - in'?

5

6

How can I keep from cry - in? for I

D⁵

7

G⁵

8

never expect to see you an - y more.

CHORUS:

My home's across the Blue Ridge Mountains,
My home's across the Blue Ridge Mountains,
My home's across the Blue Ridge Mountains,
And I never expect to see you anymore.

Rock and feed my baby candy,
Rock and feed my baby candy,
Rock and feed my baby candy,
And I never expect to see you anymore.



Key of G Roll in My Sweet Baby's Arms

Tempo: Wide Open

G

1 2 3 4

E A D G

2 4

B B A

G G E

D G

Ain't gon - na work on the rail - road,

D₅

5 6 7 8

E A D G

B B A

G F# G

A A

Ain't gon - na work on the farm,

G

9 10 11 12

E A D G

G G A

B A B

C G G

E F# E

Lay 'round the shack 'til the mail train comes back and I'll

D

13 14 15 16

E A D G

D F# G

A B A

G G

Roll in my sweet baby's arms.

CHORUS:

Roll in my sweet baby's arms,
 Roll in my sweet baby's arms,
 Lay 'round the shack
 'Til the mail train comes back,
 And I'll roll in my sweet baby's arms.

They tell me her parents do not like me,
 They have drove me away from the door,
 If I had all my time to go over,
 I would never go back any more.



Playing in the Key of A

The key of A is a favorite of many old-time and bluegrass musicians. For us ignoramuses, the good news is that both the placement of the notes and the fingering are exactly the same for the key of A and also for the key of D, which we'll learn shortly. The only difference is that we'll start the A scale on the A string open, and the D scale on the D string open. Each scale uses the same fingering, except one string over from each other.

	Index		Middle	Ring
E	F#		G#	A
A	B		C#	D

The A Scale
A, B, C#, D, E, F#, G#, A



	Open A	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger	Open E	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger
E					0	2	4	5
A	0	2	4	5				
D								
G								

E					E	F#	G#	A
A	A	B	C#	D				
D								
G								

Many A tunes can be played using just the E and A strings. On some songs, however, you'll need the complete A scale, so here it is, in all its glory.



	Index		Middle	Ring
E	F#		G#	A
A	B		C#	D
D	E		F#	G#
	A		B	C#

	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger	Open D	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger	Open A	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger	Open E	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger
E												0	2	4	5
A								0	2	4	5				
D				0	2	4	6								
G	2	4	6												

E									E	F#	G#	A
A				D	E	F#	G#	A	B	C#	D	
D												
G	A	B	C#									



Key of A

Paul and Silas

Tempo: Medium Bouncy

Chorus A

1 2 3 4

E A D G

2 4

E E F# A A C# B A

Paul and Sil - as bound in jail, all night long.

D

5 6 7 8

E A D G

F# F# G# A A A F# E

Paul and Sil - as bound in jail, all night long.

9 10 11 12

E A D G

E E F# A A C# B A

Paul and Sil - as bound in jail, all night long.

13 14 15 16

E A D G

C# C# B A B A A

Who shall de - liver for me?

Paul and Silas prayed to God,
All, night long,
Paul and Silas prayed to God,
All, night long,
Paul and Silas prayed to God,
All, night long,
Who shall deliver for me?

That old jailer locked the door,
All night long,
That old jailer locked the door,
All night long,
That old jailer locked the door,
All night long,
Who shall deliver for me?



The Key of C

Some mandolin pickers make a face when asked to play in the key of C, but actually it's one of my favorite keys to play in. Why? Because it's almost the same as playing in the key of G, except moved over one string. Let me show you. Play the G scale starting with the G note on the D string. Now do it again, using the same fingerings, but start on the low C note with your ring finger. Done? You just played a low C scale.

The C Scale C, D, E, F, G, A, B, C



	Ring Finger	Open D	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger	Open A	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger	Open E	Index Finger	Middle Finger	Ring Finger	Pinky Finger	Pinky Finger
E										0	1	3	5	7	8
A						0	2	3	5						
D		0	2	3	5										
G	5														

E										E	F	G	A	B	C
A						A	B	C	D						
D		D	E	F	G										
G	C														

THE COLD HARD TRUTH: I'm not going to pull the wool over your eyes and tell you that "Dig a Hole in the Meadow" is one of those push-over easy songs that you can play with one hand tied behind your back standing on one foot. It's not. What we have here is a wonderfully bluesy melody that you should save to play until you have many of the other tunes in this book under your belt. You'll then be ready to navigate the twists and turns of this squirrely but fun melody.

THE BLUES SCALE: After you hitch up your belt and roll up your sleeves, mess around and get familiar with the blues scale shown in the chart to the right. You'll see some strange notes in there. These notes are not really hard, they're just notes we seldom use. We'll use these same notes in "Dig a Hole in the Meadow."

	Index	Middle	Ring	Pinky
E				
A	B $\flat$	C		D $\sharp$
	D $\sharp$	E	F	G
			C	

LISTEN: Wear out the CD that comes with this book so that you're totally familiar with this tune. Try singing the words along with the notes you hear on the CD. Pay particular attention to which fingers of your left hand to use by double checking with the chart above. Once you get this tune down, you'll find it so addicting that your family will have to hit you with a stick to make you stop playing it.



Wildwood Flower

I like to think of "Wildwood Flower" as "the hill-billy national anthem" because it is the tune every country guitar player wants to play. Since guitar pickers often play it in the key of C, that's where we'll play it so they won't have to play it by themselves.

Originally titled "I'll Twine Mid the Ringlets," the Carter Family called it "Wildwood Flower" on their May 5, 1928, recording for Victor. The words were composed in 1860 by J.P. Webster and the melody by Maud Irving. By the way, Webster also composed the Civil War classic, "Lorena."

	Index	Middle	Ring
E			
A		C	D
D	E	F	G
			C



ICE COLD LICKS: This classic melody doesn't need much decorating because it's fine just the way it is.

84

WARM LICKS: If you like, you can add the Hot Dog to any of the eighth notes.



85



86

HOT LICKS: The quarter notes are a perfect place to play either the Watermelon, the Gallop or the Porcupine. Better yet, mix them up!



The Carter Family

Harmony Notes

When the melody's on the D string, play the G string as a harmony and when the melody's on the A string, use the E string for harmony. In measures 4, 9 and 18 you'll notice the melody is the C note played at the fifth fret of the G string. For harmony, you can use the D string at the second fret.



Soldier's Joy

Of all the old-time fiddle tunes, "Soldier's Joy" is certainly the granddaddy of them all. It may not be the oldest tune, but over the years it has proven itself to be the most popular and widely circulated of any fiddle tune you can name. It apparently originated in England under the title "The King's Head." One legend tells that a condemned man played it for the king and was apparently spared. Besides "Soldier's Joy," American fiddlers have called it "Payday in the Army," and "Love Somebody." First to record it were Samantha Bumgarner and Eva Davis, who traveled from western North Carolina to New York City in November of 1924. They made their mark on country music history when they sat and played their fiddle and banjo into an acoustical horn. This was back in the dawn of recording technology, when microphones were only a gleam in a recording engineer's eyes.

	Index	Middle	Ring
E	F#	G	A
A			C#
D	E		F#

"Soldiers Joy" will be a good tune for you to learn. It's so well known that you can be confident that virtually any experienced old-time or bluegrass player will know it. It's a notey little tune, so you'll need to have your D scale down solid.

STONE COLD LICKS: The sobering news is that there IS no ice cold way to play the melody of "Soldier's Joy" because there are a lot of melody notes to play. Remember when you see the eighth notes to use a DOWN stroke on the first eighth note, and an UP stroke on the second eighth note.



Photo by Wayne Erbsen

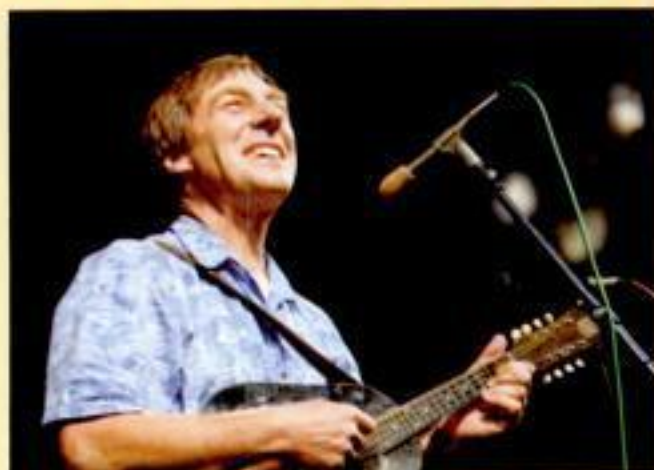


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Wayne performing at Warren Wilson College with his 1930s National Steel Mandolin

Photo by Arlin Geyer

Wayne Erbensen first started playing the mandolin in 1963 when he bought one in Mexico City for a few pesos. Since then, he has won scores of blue ribbons at fiddlers conventions in North Carolina and Virginia and along the way, has written twenty-six instruction and songbooks, and recorded eighteen solo CDs. Wayne currently teaches at Warren Wilson College and at his Log Cabin Music Center. (www.nativegroundmusic.com).

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John Hardy
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Wildwood Flower
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